

# ED-TECH WEB DESIGN BIBLE

The Complete Design System for Online College Programs

*Synthesised from Refactoring UI · Modern Industrial Design · Design Patterns · Cards · Lead-Gen Psychology*

Covers: Visual Hierarchy · Color Theory · Typography · Spacing Systems · CTA Psychology · Trust Architecture · Mobile-First  
· Conversion UX · Hero Design · Form Optimization

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CHAPTER 01

# Visual Hierarchy & Information Architecture

Every page element competes for a prospective student's attention. Your design must instantly communicate what matters most — program value, outcome, and the next action — before any reading happens.

## The Priority Pyramid

Visual hierarchy is not decoration — it is the cognitive roadmap you draw for the user. When hierarchy breaks down, visitors scan frantically, find nothing compelling, and leave. On an ed-tech lead generation page, every element belongs to one of three tiers:

|                     |                                                                                                                                                                         |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| TIER 1 · PRIMARY    | Program headline, outcome promise, primary CTA button. One dominant element per viewport. High contrast, large scale, bold weight. Nothing else competes at this level. |
| TIER 2 · SUPPORTING | Key benefits, program duration, key stats (salary uplift, placement rate). Medium contrast, moderate size. Supports the primary without overpowering.                   |
| TIER 3 · CONTEXTUAL | Accreditations, faculty names, fine print, breadcrumbs. Lower contrast, smallest scale. Necessary but deliberately understated.                                         |

## The Seven Emphasis Tools

Use these tools in combination. Never rely on font size alone — that leads to headings that are too large and body text too small.

|                            |                                                                                                                                                          |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Font Weight                | 600–700 for primary, 400–500 for body. Never use sub-400 weights in UI text.                                                                             |
| Color Contrast             | Dark/rich colours for primary, lighter tones for secondary. Never grey text on coloured backgrounds — hand-pick a hue-matched de-saturated tone instead. |
| Scale (Size)               | Only use drastic size jumps (18px → 32px) for genuine tier-1 content. Otherwise, weight and colour carry the load.                                       |
| Spatial Breathing Room     | Primary elements get more surrounding whitespace. Secondary elements are packed closer together.                                                         |
| Opacity & Saturation       | Full opacity for primary, 60–70% for secondary, 40–50% for tertiary.                                                                                     |
| Position                   | Top-left and centre receive attention first. Tier-1 CTA belongs at the natural end of the reading flow.                                                  |
| Motion (micro-interaction) | Hover states, subtle entrance animations. Primary CTAs animate; secondary elements remain static.                                                        |

## De-emphasise to Emphasise

The most powerful hierarchy technique: instead of making your hero element louder, make everything else quieter. On a program page with a primary CTA that isn't standing out, don't add more colour to the button — reduce the contrast on the supporting nav and body copy. The button will pop without changing a single property on it.

## Button Hierarchy — Semantics Are Secondary

Every page has a hierarchy of actions. Design them accordingly — not purely by their semantic meaning but by their importance to the user journey.

| Tier      | Style                                            | Ed-Tech Example                               | Use When          |
|-----------|--------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| Primary   | Solid, high-contrast fill (Orange or Royal Blue) | Apply Now · Enquire Today · Download Brochure | ONE per viewport  |
| Secondary | Outlined or low-contrast fill                    | Learn More · View Curriculum                  | 2–3 per section   |
| Tertiary  | Link-style, no border                            | Read FAQs · See Alumni Stories                | Multiple per page |

## CHAPTER 02

# Color System & Psychology

Color is trust, urgency, warmth, and authority — all at once. Ed-tech must feel credible enough for a tuition investment yet energetic enough to inspire action. This chapter defines the full palette system and every rule governing its use.

## The Ed-Tech Color Philosophy

Work exclusively in HSL (Hue, Saturation, Lightness). Hex codes are opaque — two blues that look nearly identical have nothing in common in hex. HSL lets you reason about colour: 'I need this 20% lighter' or 'more saturated'. Define your palette up front as a fixed system — never reach for the colour picker in the moment.

### Primary Palette — Trust + Action



Navy 900 Authority  
#0F2A4A



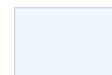
Royal 600 Primary Action  
#1A56DB



Sky 400 Links / Active  
#3B82F6



Blue 200 Light Accent  
#93C5FD



Ice 50 Bg Tint  
#EFF6FF

### CTA Palette — Energy + Conversion



Orange 700 Urgency Text  
#C2410C



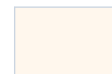
Orange 600 Hover State  
#EA580C



Orange 500 Primary CTA  
#F97316



Orange 400 Soft Badge  
#FB923C



Orange 50 Bg Tint  
#FFF7ED

### Grey Scale — Structure & Readability



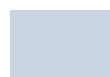
Slate 950 Headings  
#0F172A



Slate 700 Body Text  
#334155



Slate 500 Secondary  
#64748B



Slate 300 Dividers  
#CBD5E1



Slate 50 Bg / Cards  
#F8FAFC

### Semantic Palette — Status & Support



Teal 600 Success  
#0D9488



Purple 600 Premium  
#7C3AED



Amber 500 Warning  
#F59E0B



Red 600 Error  
#DC2626



Green 600 Positive KPI  
#059669

## The Shade System — 9 Steps Per Colour

Never generate shades on-the-fly with CSS lighten/darken functions — this creates dozens of barely-distinguishable variants. Pre-define 9 shades (100–900) for each primary and accent colour. Rule: no two adjacent shades should differ by less than ~25% in perceived lightness.

|                  |                                                                  |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Shade 900–800    | Text on coloured backgrounds, heading text within tinted cards   |
| Shade 700–600    | Primary CTA backgrounds, active navigation indicators            |
| Shade 500 (Base) | Brand-defining colour — the one you'd use on a button by default |
| Shade 400–300    | Hover states, icon fills, decorative elements                    |
| Shade 200–100    | Tinted backgrounds, alert boxes, card accents                    |

## CTA Color Science — Conversion Data

Color on CTA buttons is not aesthetic — it is measurable conversion science. Use this data to make decisions, not gut feeling.

| Color                | Psychology Signal                   | Conversion Impact          | Ed-Tech Use                           |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------|----------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Orange (#F97316)     | Energy, enthusiasm, urgency         | +32–40% CTR vs neutral     | Primary CTA: Apply Now, Enquire       |
| Royal Blue (#1A56DB) | Trust, professionalism, reliability | Strong brand trust         | Secondary CTA: Learn More, Download   |
| Teal/Green (#0D9488) | Success, progress, positive         | Positive action framing    | Confirm, Submit, Enrol                |
| Red (#DC2626)        | Urgency, scarcity, alert            | +21–34% for urgency promos | Deadline banners ONLY — use sparingly |

## Accessibility — WCAG Without Ugly

Contrast requirements: 4.5:1 for normal text (<18px), 3:1 for large text (≥18px bold). The secret to meeting these ratios without ugly designs is to flip contrast rather than darken. Instead of white text on a medium-blue card (often fails), use dark-blue text on a light-blue card (passes and looks refined).

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div>✓ DO</div> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Use dark navy text on light-tinted cards (ICE, ORANGE_L, TEAL_L)</li><li>• Test every text/background combo with a contrast checker</li><li>• Use icons + colour together — never colour alone</li><li>• For coloured-on-coloured text, rotate hue toward yellow/cyan for brightness</li></ul> | <div>✗ DON'T</div> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• White text on mid-saturation backgrounds (often fails 4.5:1)</li><li>• Grey text on any coloured background — hand-pick a hue-matched muted tone</li><li>• Rely on colour alone for error states, success states, or graph lines</li><li>• Use opacity reduction for de-emphasised text on colour — pick a new hand-crafted shade</li></ul> |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

CHAPTER 03

# Typography System

Typography is 95% of ed-tech design. It carries the promise, the proof, and the CTA. A constrained, intentional type system makes your UI faster to build, easier to read, and instantly more credible.

## The Ed-Tech Type Scale

Pre-define all sizes. Never nudge a font size one pixel at a time. Use px or rem — never em (em compounds in nested elements, breaking your system). This scale is optimised for a university landing page at 1440px desktop / 390px mobile.

|                  |                                    |                                               |
|------------------|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Hero H1          | 48–56px / Bold 700                 | Program name in hero section                  |
| Section H2       | 32–36px / Bold 700                 | Section headings: Why VGU, Our Programs       |
| Card H3          | 22–24px / SemiBold 600             | Program card titles, feature headings         |
| Sub-heading H4   | 18–20px / SemiBold 600             | Module names, FAQ items                       |
| Large Body       | 17–18px / Regular 400              | Hero description paragraph                    |
| Body             | 15–16px / Regular 400              | Standard page copy — all readable paragraphs  |
| Small / Caption  | 13–14px / Regular 400              | Labels, metadata, dates, fine print           |
| Overline / Tag   | 11–12px / SemiBold 600 / UPPERCASE | Course tags, badge labels, section pre-labels |
| Legal / Footnote | 10–11px / Regular 400              | Disclaimer, copyright                         |

## Font Selection Rules

For an ed-tech brand targeting working professionals and Gen-Z learners, the personality should be: confident, modern, approachable, but not childish.

|                     |                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Primary (Headlines) | Inter, Plus Jakarta Sans, Manrope, or DM Sans. Choose fonts with 5+ weights and good x-height. Avoid condensed faces for body. |
| Body / UI           | Same family as primary at Regular 400 for consistency, or pair with a neutral sans like Roboto / Open Sans.                    |
| Accent / Display    | A single serif (like Playfair Display) used only for testimonial pull-quotes or hero sub-taglines — adds warmth and authority. |
| Avoid               | Decorative fonts, fonts with <4 weights, any font that degrades below 14px. Never mix more than 2 type families on one page.   |

## Line Length, Height & Spacing

Readability is a conversion lever. Hard-to-read pages feel untrustworthy, and students close them. These rules are non-negotiable.

|                               |                                                                                                                                                        |
|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Line Length</b>            | 45–75 characters per line. Set paragraph max-width to 65–70ch or 600–680px. Wider content = harder to follow the line return. Tighter = feels cramped. |
| <b>Line Height (body)</b>     | 1.6–1.7 for standard body copy at 15–16px. Wider columns need taller line-height.                                                                      |
| <b>Line Height (headings)</b> | 1.1–1.2 for H1/H2. Large text needs tighter leading — 1.5 on a 48px heading looks airy and weak.                                                       |
| <b>Letter Spacing</b>         | Tighten headlines: -0.02em to -0.03em. Normal for body. +0.06em to +0.1em for ALL-CAPS tags and overlines — caps need breathing room.                  |
| <b>Alignment</b>              | Left-align body copy always. Centre only for headlines ≤2 lines, stats numbers, or standalone pull-quotes. Never centre paragraphs.                    |
| <b>Baseline Alignment</b>     | When mixing font sizes on one line (stat + label), align to the text baseline, not vertical centre — centred baselines create awkward optical gaps.    |

CHAPTER 04

# Layout, Spacing & Grid

Layout and spacing are the invisible architecture of your page. Generous, intentional spacing communicates quality, trust, and clarity — the exact signals a prospective student needs to feel confident about an investment.

## The 8-Point Spacing System

All spacing and sizing values must come from a pre-defined scale based on multiples of 4px. The 8-point base means consistent increments that are visually distinguishable. This eliminates decision fatigue and produces natural, harmonious layouts.

|        |                                                                 |
|--------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 4px    | Tight internal padding — icon-to-text gaps, badge inner padding |
| 8px    | Minimum component padding — small chips, tight labels           |
| 12px   | Compact card padding, form field inner padding                  |
| 16px   | Standard component padding — buttons (vertical), card inner     |
| 24px   | Section sub-element gaps, list item spacing                     |
| 32px   | Card-to-card spacing, row gaps in grids                         |
| 48px   | Major section internal padding top/bottom                       |
| 64px   | Section-to-section vertical rhythm                              |
| 96px   | Hero top/bottom padding, above-the-fold breathing room          |
| 128px+ | Full-bleed section separators on desktop                        |

## Start With Too Much Space

The single most reliable way to clean up any design: start by adding more space than feels necessary, then reduce until it feels right. White space is not empty — it is breathing room that signals quality. Dense ed-tech pages feel like they are hiding something. Open pages feel like a confident institution.

## Max-Width Strategy

Don't stretch content to fill the whole screen. Give each element the width it needs, not more.

|                      |                                                                            |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Page wrapper         | 1280px max-width, centred — prevents ultra-wide uncomfortable line lengths |
| Hero text block      | 640–720px — keeps headline readable at all viewport widths                 |
| Body copy paragraphs | 65ch / ~600px — the sweet spot for reading speed and comfort               |

|                   |                                                                      |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lead capture form | 480–520px — narrow enough to feel focused, wide enough for usability |
| Program cards     | 340–380px per card in a 3-column grid                                |
| Stats row         | Full container width — stats read better in a wide horizontal band   |

## Ambiguous Spacing — The Silent Killer

When related elements have the same spacing as unrelated ones, the brain works harder to parse the page. This creates friction — subconscious friction that makes users feel vaguely uncomfortable without knowing why. Fix: spacing within a group must always be smaller than spacing between groups.

### ✓ DO

- Form label: 4px above input, 20px above next label group
- Program cards: 16px internal padding, 32px between cards
- Section heading: 8px above first paragraph, 48px above the section itself
- Bullet list: 4–6px between bullets, 20px before/after the list block

### ✗ DON'T

- Equal spacing between label and input as between form groups
- Same gap between card title and body as between two separate cards
- Section heading that visually floats between two sections rather than attaching to one
- Navigation items with same gap as hero-to-navigation gap

CHAPTER 05

# Depth, Shadows & Dimension

Depth is not decoration — it is a communication tool. Shadows tell the user what is interactive, what is elevated, and what is background. Used correctly, they make complex pages feel organised and intuitive.

## The Light Source Model

All shadows in a single design must assume a single, consistent light source: coming from above and slightly in front of the screen. This means shadows are cast downward. Top edges of raised elements are lighter. Bottom edges are slightly darker. Violating this rule — even subtly — creates an uncanny, unsettling feeling.

## The Five-Level Shadow Scale

| Level                           | CSS Value                                   | Use Case                                                   |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Shadow 1 (flat / barely lifted) | box-shadow: 0 1px 2px rgba(15,42,74,0.08)   | Form inputs, table rows, very subtle card outlines         |
| Shadow 2 (low elevation)        | box-shadow: 0 2px 8px rgba(15,42,74,0.10)   | Standard cards, program tiles, stat boxes                  |
| Shadow 3 (medium elevation)     | box-shadow: 0 4px 16px rgba(15,42,74,0.12)  | Sticky navigation on scroll, feature highlight cards       |
| Shadow 4 (high elevation)       | box-shadow: 0 8px 24px rgba(15,42,74,0.14)  | Dropdowns, tooltips, hover-lifted cards                    |
| Shadow 5 (modal / overlay)      | box-shadow: 0 20px 48px rgba(15,42,74,0.20) | Modal dialogs, brochure download popups, sticky lead forms |

## Depth Without Shadows — Flat Techniques

When your design language skews flat or neumorphic, use colour relationships to create the perception of depth.

|                     |                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lighter = closer    | Cards that are lighter than the page background feel raised. Use white on a slate-50 background.                               |
| Darker = recessed   | Input fields darker than the card background feel inset — signals 'type here'.                                                 |
| Overlap layers      | A CTA card that crosses the boundary between a dark hero section and a light body section immediately feels three-dimensional. |
| Solid colour shadow | A 2–3px solid offset below a card (no blur) creates a flat but tangible sense of lift.                                         |
| Border + background | A subtle 1px SLATE-3 border on a white card on a SLATE-50 background creates crisp, legible separation without any shadow.     |

CHAPTER 06

# Hero Sections & Above-the-Fold Design

The hero is your 5-second window. Research shows 94% of first impressions are design-driven, and prospective students decide whether to stay or leave within the first scroll. Everything in the hero must do a specific conversion job.

## Hero Anatomy — 7 Required Elements

|                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Pre-headline tag           | Small ALL-CAPS overline (e.g. 'ONLINE MBA PROGRAM') above the headline. Sets context before the emotional hook. Use brand colour at 11px with +0.1em letter-spacing.                                                                        |
| 2. Headline — Outcome Promise | The single most important line on the page. Format: [Action/Transformation] + [Outcome]. Example: 'Advance to Senior Management — In 18 Months.' 48–56px, Bold 700, NAVY.                                                                   |
| 3. Sub-headline               | 1–2 sentences expanding the promise with specifics. Mode of study, duration, key differentiator. 17–18px, Regular 400, SLATE-700.                                                                                                           |
| 4. Trust proof bar            | 3–4 concise proof points below the sub-headline: '12,000+ Graduates · UGC Approved · 100% Online · EMI Available'. 13px SemiBold, icon-prefixed.                                                                                            |
| 5. Primary CTA                | One high-contrast Orange button: 'Apply Now' or 'Enquire Today'. Minimum 48×52px. Right of or below the sub-headline.                                                                                                                       |
| 6. Secondary CTA              | Outlined or ghost button: 'Download Brochure'. Same line as primary. Never compete visually.                                                                                                                                                |
| 7. Hero visual                | Right side: real student photo, video thumbnail, or illustrated outcome scene. Always apply a subtle dark overlay or colorize to ensure consistent text contrast if text is overlaid. No generic stock photos of people looking at laptops. |

## Background Image Treatment

Text on photos is a contrast trap. The photo is dynamic — light here, dark there — and no single text colour will work across the whole image. Use one of these four solutions:

|                                      |                                                                                                                                                         |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Semi-transparent overlay             | Apply <code>rgba(15,42,74,0.55)</code> dark overlay. Use white text on top. Preserves photo emotion while guaranteeing contrast. $\geq 4.5:1$ required. |
| Colour-tinted overlay                | Desaturate photo + multiply with brand colour. Creates cohesive brand aesthetic. Example: blue-tinted hero = consistent and professional.               |
| Reduced-contrast image + text shadow | Lower photo contrast to 70%, add text-shadow: 0 2px 12px <code>rgba(0,0,0,0.4)</code> on headlines. More dynamic, requires testing across breakpoints.  |

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**Split layout (no overlay needed)**

60% text block on solid brand colour, 40% photo panel. Clean, high-contrast, no risk. Recommended for mobile-first.

CHAPTER 07

# CTA & Conversion Architecture

Every design decision either increases or decreases the probability of a lead form submission. This chapter defines the conversion system: from button design to form psychology to urgency mechanisms that feel genuine, not manipulative.

## The CTA Button — 8 Non-Negotiables

|                               |                                                                                                                                             |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Contrast ratio             | CTA must contrast $\geq 4.5:1$ against its background. Orange (#F97316) on white = $3.1:1$ — use darker Orange-600 (#EA580C) for body CTAs. |
| 2. Size & hit target          | Minimum 44×44px (mobile), 48×52px (desktop). Padding: 14–16px vertical, 24–32px horizontal. Never make CTAs too small to tap comfortably.   |
| 3. Action verb first          | 'Apply Now', 'Enquire Today', 'Download Brochure' — never 'Submit', 'Go', or 'Click Here'. The verb must communicate the outcome.           |
| 4. One CTA per decision point | One primary CTA per viewport. Two primary CTAs compete and reduce clicks on both.                                                           |
| 5. Border radius              | 8–12px radius for approachable softness. Full-pill (9999px) for secondary ghost buttons. Maintain consistency across page.                  |
| 6. Hover state                | On hover: darken background by ~10% OR add upward shadow (2px lift). Never just underline. Feedback = confidence = clicks.                  |
| 7. Loading/processing state   | Spinner or 'Submitting...' text swap. Prevents double submissions and signals responsiveness.                                               |
| 8. Surrounding white space    | CTA must have breathing room — minimum 16px clear space above and below. Never crowd a CTA.                                                 |

## Lead Form Optimisation

The lead form is the most friction-filled moment in the user journey. Every unnecessary field is a leak in your conversion funnel. Reduce, clarify, and reassure.

|                  |                                                                                                                                                     |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Field count      | 3–4 fields maximum for first-touch lead capture: Name, Phone, Email, Program of Interest. Progressive profiling collects more over time.            |
| Field labels     | Always above the input, never inside as placeholder-only. Placeholder text disappears on focus, leaving users confused.                             |
| Input styling    | Inset appearance (slightly darker bg or subtle inner shadow). Active/focus state: Royal Blue border 2px. Error state: Red-600 border + icon + text. |
| CTA button       | Inside the form, full-width, Orange-500. Label: 'Get Free Counselling' beats 'Submit'. Outcome-framed wins every time.                              |
| Trust micro-copy | Beneath the submit button: '■ No spam. Your info stays private.' Removes the #1 objection to form fills.                                            |

|                       |                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Mobile layout</b>  | Single-column always on mobile. Inputs minimum 48px height. Font-size $\geq 16$ px inside inputs (prevents iOS zoom). |
| <b>Smart defaults</b> | Pre-select the most popular program. Auto-detect location for state/country fields. Reduce cognitive load.            |

## Urgency & Social Proof Patterns

Urgency must be real or it destroys trust. Use genuine scarcity (intake deadlines, seat limits) and authentic social proof.

|                             |                                                                                                                           |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Intake countdown</b>     | Real deadline timer: 'Next intake closes in 12 days.' Subtle Amber banner, not aggressive red. Only use if actually true. |
| <b>Seat scarcity</b>        | 'Only 23 seats remaining in this batch.' Use when accurate. Adds urgency without pressure-selling.                        |
| <b>Live activity</b>        | '38 students enquired about this program this week.' Social proof as urgency: FOMO + validation.                          |
| <b>Cohort social proof</b>  | 'Join 340 professionals already enrolled in 2025 batch.' Normalises the action. Reduces hesitation.                       |
| <b>Alumni outcome proof</b> | Not just 'our graduates succeed' — 'Rahul went from █6L to █18L CTC in 14 months. Class of 2023.' Specific = believable.  |

CHAPTER 08

Program & Course Page Design

Program pages are where interest converts to enquiry. They must answer every question a prospective student has — in the right order, at the right depth — while continuously reinforcing the decision to apply.

Page Section Sequence (Proven Conversion Order)

|                                     |                                                                              |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Hero (above fold)                | Program name, outcome promise, duration/mode, dual CTA                       |
| 2. Social proof bar                 | Stats: graduates, rating, placement rate, industry partners                  |
| 3. Program overview                 | Who it's for, key outcomes, career transformation                            |
| 4. Curriculum                       | Accordion — semester/module breakdown. Downloadable PDF link.                |
| 5. Why choose us                    | 3–4 differentiators with icons. Not bullet lists — visual cards.             |
| 6. Faculty                          | Real faces, real credentials. 3–4 featured. Link to full faculty page.       |
| 7. Student testimonials             | Video > text. Include name, company, role post-graduation.                   |
| 8. Career outcomes                  | Salary data, company logos (Tier-1 employers), job title transformations     |
| 9. Admission process                | 3–4 step visual process. Removes fear of 'how complicated is this?'          |
| 10. FAQ                             | 5–7 top objections answered. Use accordion. Reduces support load.            |
| 11. Sticky CTA / Floating lead form | Always visible. 'Apply Now' on scroll. On mobile: fixed bottom bar with CTA. |

Program Card Anatomy

Where multiple programs are shown in a grid, every card must communicate the same information consistently. Visual uniformity enables comparison — and comparison drives decisions.

|                  |                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Card image/icon  | Program category icon or relevant abstract image. Fixed 200px height, object-fit: cover. Apply a 2px Royal Blue top border accent. |
| Program tag      | 11px ALL-CAPS badge: 'ONLINE · FULL-TIME' or 'WEEKEND BATCH'. Orange-50 background, Orange-700 text.                               |
| Program title    | 22–24px Bold. Max 2 lines. Truncate with ellipsis if needed.                                                                       |
| 1-line outcome   | 14px italic Slate-700: 'Designed for marketing professionals targeting Director roles'                                             |
| Key specs row    | Duration · Mode · Next Intake — iconified, 13px, Slate-500                                                                         |
| Fee / EMI teaser | Optional: '■1,800/month onwards'. Removes fee anxiety early.                                                                       |
| CTA button       | Full-width 'Explore Program' — Secondary style. Orange only on featured card.                                                      |

## CHAPTER 09

# Trust, Proof & Credibility Design

Online education purchases require more trust than almost any other online transaction. Students are committing months of time and lakhs of rupees. Every trust signal must be visible, specific, and credible.

## The Trust Signal Hierarchy

|                                    |                                                                                             |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Tier 1: Institutional trust</b> | UGC recognition, NAAC grade, AICTE approval — above the fold or in hero trust bar           |
| <b>Tier 2: Outcome trust</b>       | Placement rates, salary data, employer brand logos — mid-page after interest is established |
| <b>Tier 3: Peer trust</b>          | Student testimonials, alumni count, cohort diversity — emotionally reinforces the decision  |
| <b>Tier 4: Process trust</b>       | Secure payment badges, privacy policy, refund policy — near the form/pricing                |
| <b>Tier 5: Expert trust</b>        | Faculty credentials, industry advisors, media mentions — supporting, not primary            |

## Testimonial Design Rules

Testimonials are not marketing copy — they are proof. Weak testimonials ('Great course! Highly recommend!') hurt more than they help because they feel fabricated. Design for specificity and humanity.

|                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Format</b>           | Quote → Name → Role (Before → After) → Company logo. Always include the 'before' role — transformation requires a starting point.                                                                 |
| <b>Photo</b>            | Real headshot, not stock. Circular crop, 64–80px diameter. Initials fallback with brand colour bg if no photo.                                                                                    |
| <b>Quote size</b>       | Display at 20–24px for pull-quote style. Large quotes feel authoritative. Attribution at 13px, lighter colour.                                                                                    |
| <b>Quote marks</b>      | Oversized decorative quotation marks (60–80px, brand colour, low opacity) behind the quote text. Visual anchor without noise.                                                                     |
| <b>Carousel vs grid</b> | Grid of 3 (desktop): shows volume and variety simultaneously. Carousel: only if >6 testimonials. Auto-play carousels are conversion killers — users never trust them; use manual-only navigation. |

## Numbers & Statistics Design

Stats are your most efficient trust tool — but only if they are visually prominent and specific. '12,000 graduates' beats 'thousands of graduates'. '■14.2L average CTC' beats 'high salary potential'.

|                          |                                                                          |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Number size</b>       | 48–64px Bold, brand color. The number is tier-1 hierarchy. Huge.         |
| <b>Label size</b>        | 14–16px Regular, Slate-700. The label is tier-3. Small and understated.  |
| <b>Accompanying icon</b> | 24–32px icon above or beside the number. Same brand colour, 60% opacity. |

|             |                                                                                                                                            |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Layout      | 4 stats in a horizontal band (full-width section). Soft gradient or light-tinted background. Not inside a card — it shrinks them visually. |
| Specificity | Include a source or year: '2024 Placement Report'. Specificity = credibility.                                                              |

CHAPTER 10

# Finishing Touches, Polish & Mobile Checklist

Great designs are distinguished by the details that most people never notice consciously — but feel. These are the finishing moves that separate a template-looking page from a brand-consistent, conversion-optimised digital campus.

## Accent Borders — The Cheapest Design Win

A 3–4px coloured border on any otherwise plain white card instantly makes it feel 'designed'. No illustration budget needed. This technique from Refactoring UI is exceptionally effective in ed-tech for card systems.

|                           |                                                                                |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Top of program cards      | 3px Royal Blue top border. Signals 'this is an official program'.              |
| Active navigation item    | 3px Orange bottom border on the active tab/link.                               |
| Alert / info banners      | 4px Royal Blue left border on info callouts. 4px Red left border for warnings. |
| Section heading underline | Short 40px Orange line beneath H2 section headings. Adds anchor.               |
| Page header / nav top     | 4px Royal Blue top strip on the very top of the viewport.                      |
| Testimonial cards         | 3px Teal left border. Distinguishes testimonials visually from other cards.    |

## Background Decoration — Subtle Life

|                            |                                                                                                                             |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Section colour alternation | Alternate white and Slate-50 (#F8FAFC) sections. Creates visual rhythm without borders. Never alternate two strong colours. |
| Gradient hero              | linear-gradient(135deg, #0F2A4A 0%, #1A56DB 100%) for hero bands. Keep hue rotation ≤30° or it looks garish.                |
| Geometric shapes           | Large, low-opacity (5–8%) circles or polygons in brand colour as background elements. Adds depth without clutter.           |
| Subtle dot/grid patterns   | CSS dot pattern at 10–12px spacing, 4–6% opacity. Adds texture to otherwise flat sections.                                  |
| Colourised image bands     | Desaturated + tinted background images for section dividers. Keep contrast with text always ≥4.5:1.                         |

## Micro-Copy & Empty States

Micro-copy is the small text that lives in the margins: button labels, form hints, error messages, empty state messages. It is the most-read and least-designed copy on any page.

|                     |                                                                                                                                          |
|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Form error messages | Specific, not generic. 'Please enter a 10-digit mobile number' not 'Invalid input'. Red-600 text + icon. Appears inline below the field. |
|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

|                      |                                                                                                                                          |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Input hint text      | Below the label, Slate-500, 12px: 'We'll only call during business hours.'                                                               |
| Success confirmation | After form submit: specific next step. 'Thanks Priya! Our counsellor will call you within 2 hours.' Not just 'Thank you for submitting.' |
| Empty program list   | If a filter returns no results: illustration + 'No programs match. Try removing a filter or browse all programs.' Include a CTA.         |
| Page 404             | Custom design. Not the server default. 'This page moved. Here are our most popular programs.' Recover the lead.                          |

Mobile-First Checklist

Gen-Z prospective students are mobile-first. Over 70% of ed-tech traffic arrives on mobile. These are the non-negotiable mobile checks before any page goes live.

- Tap targets ≥44×44px — test every button and link
- Font size ≥16px inside all form inputs (prevents iOS auto-zoom)
- Hero headline ≤32px on mobile — 48px desktop headlines are too large on 390px screens
- Single-column layout — no horizontal scrolling anywhere
- Fixed bottom CTA bar: 'Apply Now' always visible on program pages
- Images: WebP format, max 200KB hero, lazy-load below-fold images
- Page load ≤3 seconds on 4G — test with Lighthouse
- Navigation: hamburger menu with full-screen overlay. Close button visible.
- Forms: single-column, large inputs, dropdown for program selection
- Video: poster image while loading, controls visible, captions available
- Spacing: 16px horizontal padding minimum on all content. Never flush-to-edge.
- Shadow-5 modals: full-screen on mobile. Not the desktop floating-card style.
- All hover states also have focus states (keyboard + screen reader accessibility)
- Phone numbers: all are tap-to-call links (tel: protocol)
- WhatsApp CTA: floating WhatsApp button on all program pages

The Quality Bar — Final Audit Pass

Before any page launches, run this quick audit. If any item fails, fix it.

| Design Element | Pass Criteria                                                                            |
|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hierarchy      | Can I identify Tier-1, Tier-2, Tier-3 at a glance in 5 seconds?                          |
| Color          | Primary CTA uses Orange. All text passes 4.5:1 contrast. No solo-colour information.     |
| Typography     | Max 2 fonts. Type scale is consistent. No font below 10px visible to user.               |
| Spacing        | No ambiguous spacing. Related elements are closer than unrelated ones.                   |
| Shadows        | All cards use the same shadow level. Modals use Shadow-5.                                |
| CTA            | One primary CTA per viewport. Action verb. Minimum 44px height.                          |
| Trust          | Accreditation logo above fold. At least 2 specific testimonials. Stats visible mid-page. |

|        |                                                                                       |
|--------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Mobile | Single column. Tap targets ≥44px. Load time ≤3s. Fixed bottom CTA bar.                |
| Forms  | ≤4 fields. Labels above fields. Privacy assurance below submit button.                |
| Images | No grey placeholder images in production. No scaled-up icons. Alt text on all images. |

*This Bible was synthesised from Refactoring UI (Adam Wathan & Steve Schoger), modern industry standards for ed-tech UI/UX (2025–2026), and conversion-rate optimisation research for higher education lead generation. Apply it as a living system — test, iterate, and let data refine the rules.*